

Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE

GLASSHOUSE

WAR OF THE VETERANS

The tussle between Rajasthan chief minister Ashok Gehlot and Union minister and BJP leader Gajendra Singh Shekhawat has been getting uglier every day. Shekhawat has taken Gehlot's government to task on law and order and the budget. Gehlot has state agencies investigating allegations of Shekhawat's role in a cooperative society fund scam and in the attempt to topple his government in 2020, but there has been little headway. Recently, at a rally in Jodhpur, the hometown of both leaders, Gehlot said the Centre had raised Shekhawat's security cover so that the agencies could not arrest him. Shekhawat retorted that it was news to him that people with security cover could not be arrested. On Shekhawat's FIR in Delhi against the illegal tapping of his phone, the Delhi police interrogated Gehlot's OSD Lokesh Sharma for the third time in February.

Stalin's Spanner

Bharat Rashtra Samithi chief and Telangana chief minister **K. Chandrashekar Rao's** grand ambition to become prime minister by forging a pan-India electoral alliance opposed to the BJP but without the Congress has stumbled at an unexpected juncture. Tamil Nadu chief minister and DMK president M.K. Stalin has asked KCR to serve the people of his own state, betraying his reluctance to back the BRS in the 2024 general election. He has called for support for an anti-BJP front at the national level that includes the Congress. But KCR, egged on by soothsayers, is charting his own course.



ANI

WHO MOVES FIRST?





This one's for a political love guru to resolve. At the 11th general convention of the CPI(M) in Patna on February 18, when Bihar chief minister **Nitish Kumar** appealed to the Congress to make a move in uniting the Opposition, Congress leader **Salman Khurshid** expressed a peculiar dilemma. Nitish said BJP could be restricted to 100 seats in 2024 if the Congress initiated a dialogue with the potential constituents of the proposed anti-BJP alliance. While Khurshid assured Nitish his party was on the same page as him, he said: *"Kabhi Kabhi pyaar mein ek samasya hoti hai, ki pehle kaun kahega* 'I love you' (sometimes the problem in love is who says 'I love you' first)."

Kaushik Deka with Rohit Parihar, Amarnath K. Menon, Jumana Shah, Amitabh Srivastava and Romita Datta



UPFRONT



No Power Hunger Here

A few weeks ago, Gujarat chief minister Bhupendra Patel started the practice of switching off all fans, air conditioners and lights when the office was not in use. On odd occasions, he would switch off the lights himself before leaving. Ministers and their secretaries mocked the move, pointing to the practice of cooling cars and cabins of bureaucrats beforehand so that the space would be comfortable by the time they arrived. Interestingly, though, when the tattle reached the CM, rather than retort, he went about the task as usual. Inspired (or shamed?), at least a few senior bureaucrats have started doing the same.

WANING MAGIC

It was 'Khela Hobe' all over again as **Mamata Banerjee's** West Bengal took on Saurashtra, the home turf of Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Union home minister Amit Shah, at Kolkata's Eden Gardens in the final of the Ranji Trophy match. Bengal's sports and youth affairs minister Manoj Tiwary led the state team from the front, convinced that Bengal would replicate the rout on the 22 yards that Didi had accomplished in the political field. As luck would have it, Bengal lost the match. Has *khela hobe* run its course then as a motivating slogan?